

Figure 3.5 *Jam: minaret of Jam (c. 1180) [*sic*], general view. © Photograph Josephine Powell c. 1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

building conventions had been shaped throughout the previous two centuries by the robust patronage of the Saljuqs and the military aristocracy of the Ghaznavids. Thus, increased means and access to the necessary skilled workers meant that the Shansabanis could commission the whole range of architectural forms within the former's repertory, including mosques, *minar*s, *madrasa*s, *'idgah*s, and a variety of other buildings.

Indeed, the well-known Jam-Firuzkuh *minar* (Figure 3.5), discussed in further detail in Chapter 4, may provide an *iconographic* hint of the prior existence of an *'idgah* if not a mosque – neighboring the *minar*. In her re-examination of the *minar*, archaeologist and epigraphist Janine Sourdel-Thomine painstakingly analyzed its epigraphic and decorative program. While the significance and uniqueness of the entirety of Surat Maryam (Qur'an XIX) on the *minar*'s lower shaft is addressed in the following chapter, here it is useful to highlight the low-relief motif of a blind arch on its east–west axis (Figure 3.6): nestled among the complex web of Qur'anic and historical inscriptions, and geometrical and vegetal